

TUSHAR TANKARIYA

COSTLY GAFFE (Left) Kshatriya Samaj rally against Rupala in Rajkot; (inset) Parshottam Rupala

community—of which the erstwhile royals were a part—up in arms. As their ire mounted, not just against Rupala but also the BJP, the Union minister apologised profusely in public, saying, "I never meant what I said. It is a matter of great regret for me that such words came out of my mouth." But the self-flagellation did little to appease the Kshatriyas, who termed the apology as nothing but a poll ploy, and are not willing to settle for anything less than the withdrawal of Rupala's candidature.

What does not help matters is the fact that Rupala is a Kadva Patel. A subcaste of the Patidars, the community has had a chequered history with the Kshatriyas in Saurashtra, dating back to the Congress politics of the '80s. The KHAM (Kshatriya, Harijan, Adivasi and Muslims) equation that the late Congress leader and former chief minister Madhavsinh Solanki had devised in the state had pointedly excluded the Patidars from the power quartet, pitting the two communities against each other. Murders of community members on both sides had only deepened that enmity. The rivalry seemed to have been somewhat subsumed by the BJP pushing a wider Hindu identity, but seems had never left. While the BJP is now working hard to ensure old fault lines do not reemerge, the recent fracas has found it walking a tightrope ahead of the election.

Leaders of the community have been leveraging social media and poster warfare to reach out to their brethren across the country to make Rupala's alleged slight to the Rajputs a national issue. There have been fast, threats of *jauhar* (self-immolation) and public statements. After another failed meeting between the Kshatriya leaders of the BJP and a committee of the community leaders of Rajputs (a subset of the Kshatriyas) on April 3, Rajput Coordination Committee convenor Karansinh Chavda said, "We will not compromise. We have no problem with BJP, our only demand is to remove Rupala as a candidate... They have to decide whether 22 crore Rajputs living in the country, including 75 lakh in Gujarat are dearer or Rupala." The community, he went on to add, will field multiple independent candidates on the Rajkot seat and campaign against the BJP on all 26 seats, with Rajput communities from Maharashtra, Rajasthan and Madhya Pradesh joining in, if their demand is not met.

RUPALA'S STATEMENT HAS CRACKED OPEN THE OLD PATIDAR-KSHATRIYA FAULT LINES THE BJP HAD SUBSUMED UNDER A WIDER HINDU IDENTITY

The BJP has made repeated attempts to placate the community, but insisted that Rupala will not be replaced. Withdrawing a senior leader like the Union minister will mean a loss of face, which the party wants to avoid at all costs. It will also risk upsetting the Patidars who constitute 14-16 per cent of the Gujarat electorate, impacting up to seven Lok Sabha seats in the state. Kshatriya votes, by contrast, are 5-6 per cent and do not decisively impact any of the 26 seats. Gujarat goes to the polls on May 7 and Rupala has continued his campaign amid the raging controversy.

What everyone is asking, though, is how far the protest will impact the BJP's prospects if the community lives up to its threat and indeed fields independent candidates against the saffron side. Most political observers dismiss it as a storm in a teacup. "BJP will be impacted only if the community sides with the Congress. Fielding independent candidates will achieve nothing substantial," says a political historian on condition of anonymity. While the Kshatriya leaders of the Congress have disparaged Rupala's remarks, terming them an irreversible insult to the community whose ancestors have laid down their lives for the country, former leader of the Opposition and Leuva Patidar leader Paresh Dhanani has tweeted a poem in support of the protesters. Dhanani has also urged the Patidar community to not react to the protests against Rupala, as the Kshatriya protests are not against the Patidars, but the minister. It's an open war. And against a side known for its martial antecedents. ■